

Module 2: Migration Data and Global Trends

Graduate Research Project

Auditing the Numbers: A Critical Evaluation of a Global Migration Dataset

Overview

Select one major migration dataset (UN DESA international migrant stock, IOM Missing Migrants, UNHCR refugee statistics, or World Bank remittances) and audit it: how the data are produced, what they systematically miss, and how they are used politically.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Critique data reliability and bias (Grad 1)
- Propose improved data approaches (Grad 2)

Sample research questions

- What definitional and collection choices shape the dataset, and which populations do they render invisible?
- How has this dataset been used (or misused) in policy or media debates?
- What concrete, feasible changes would most improve its coverage of children, undocumented people, or people with disabilities?

Methods

Documentary analysis of the dataset's methodology papers plus a reproducible descriptive analysis (spreadsheet or notebook) demonstrating at least one blind spot empirically — e.g., comparing two sources that should agree but do not.

IRB / research ethics

Not required — published aggregate data only.

Deliverables

- 3,500–4,500-word data audit with the reproducible analysis appended
- One-page 'improved data approach' proposal written for a policy audience

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Technical understanding of how the data are produced 25%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: technical understanding of how the data are produced goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: technical understanding of how the data are produced is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: technical understanding of how the data are produced is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: technical understanding of how the data are produced is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.
Quality of the empirical demonstration 30%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: quality of the empirical demonstration goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: quality of the empirical demonstration is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: quality of the empirical demonstration is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: quality of the empirical demonstration is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.
Insight of the bias/politics critique 25%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: insight of the bias/politics critique goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: insight of the bias/politics critique is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: insight of the bias/politics critique is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: insight of the bias/politics critique is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Feasibility and specificity of the improvement proposal 20%	Design judgment is excellent: feasibility and specificity of the improvement proposal is fully addressed — costs, constraints, politics, and failure modes are named honestly and the proposal remains workable anyway.	Design judgment is good: feasibility and specificity of the improvement proposal is addressed for the major factors, with minor blind spots that would not sink the proposal.	Design judgment is limited: feasibility and specificity of the improvement proposal is addressed superficially — key constraints or failure modes are ignored, making the proposal fragile.	Design judgment is missing: feasibility and specificity of the improvement proposal is not addressed; the proposal ignores obvious constraints and would not survive contact with reality.